suggested abandoning Lysenkoism and accepting Darwinism risked the gulag or a bullet to the head. Lysenkoism's legacy haunted Soviet science and agronomy for decades and was one reason why by the early 1970s the USSR ceased to be a major exporter of grain and became a net importer, despite its vast fertile lands.[114]

The same dynamic characterised many other fields of activity. For instance, during the 1930s Soviet industry suffered from numerous accidents. This was largely the fault of the Soviet bosses in Moscow, who set up almost impossible goals for industrialisation and viewed any failure to achieve them as treason. In the effort to fulfil the ambitious goals, safety measures and quality-control checks were abandoned, and experts who advised prudence were often reprimanded or shot. The result was a wave of industrial accidents, dysfunctional products and wasted efforts. Instead of taking responsibility, Moscow concluded that this must be the handiwork of the global Trotskyite-imperialist conspiracy of saboteurs and terrorists bent on derailing the Soviet enterprise. Rather than slow down and adopt safety regulations, the bosses redoubled the terror and shot more people.

A famous case in point was Pavel Rychagov. He was one of the best and bravest Soviet pilots, leading missions to help the Republicans in the Spanish Civil War and the Chinese against the Japanese invasion. He quickly rose through the ranks, becoming commander of the Soviet air force in August 1940, aged twenty-nine. But the courage that helped Rychagov shoot down Nazi aeroplanes in Spain landed him in deep trouble in Moscow. The Soviet air force suffered from numerous accidents, which the Politburo blamed on lack of discipline and deliberate sabotage by anti-Soviet conspiracies. Rychagov, however, wouldn't buy this official line. As a frontline pilot, he knew the truth. He flatly told Stalin that pilots were being forced to operate hastily designed and badly produced aeroplanes, which he compared to flying 'in coffins'. Two days after Hitler invaded the Soviet Union, as the Red Army was collapsing and Stalin was desperately hunting for scapegoats, Rychagov was arrested for 'being a member of an anti-Soviet conspiratorial organisation and carrying out enemy work aimed at weakening the power of the Red Army'. His wife was also arrested, because she allegedly knew about his 'Trotskyist ties with the military conspirators'. They were executed on 28 October 1941.[115]

The real saboteur who wrecked Soviet military efforts wasn't Rychagov, of course, but Stalin himself. For years, Stalin feared that a clash to the